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Session D1-S6-Z1-CP1: Archives, Memory, and Cultural Heritage

E-mergency of Memory

Archiving Grief in the Age of Platform Precarity

A mixed-methods study of memorialized social media accounts as emergent sites of collective grief and digital heritage

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Introduction: The Emergency of Memory

Hundreds of millions

deceased-user profiles projected to be hosted on Facebook alone by 2024

Some researchers project dead accounts could outnumber the living before the century's end.

Öhman & Watson, 2019 · ExpressVPN, 2024

Facebook has quietly become “**the world’s largest cemetery**” — governed not by law or custom, but by a Terms of Service and an opaque algorithm.



Profiles outlive their owners

Walls fill with condolences; comment threads become rolling memorial books.



Governed by Terms of Service, not heritage law

No platform offers an institutional guarantee of long-term preservation.



Bereaved communities respond with ‘curatorial labour’

Screenshotting, building shared drives, and deploying extraction tools to rescue digital remains.

Curatorial Labour & Digital Solidarity

Responding to the conference theme of Emergence/ia: memorialized profiles are not passive tombstones, but dynamic, contested, emergent spaces — where grief is performed, contested, and institutionalized from below.



Curatorial Labour

The often-invisible work of screenshotting, downloading, organizing, and sharing memorial content — performed by surviving communities without institutional support or formal training.



Digital Solidarity

An emergent, decentralized form of collective archiving — grassroots, affectively motivated, and named and systematically studied for the first time in this paper.

Thanatosociology & the ‘Second Death’



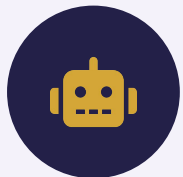
Digital Souls (Stokes, 2021)

Social network profiles are a materially distinct instantiation of personhood — one that can survive biological death as an ‘ethical patient’ in our lifeworld.



Deletion as ‘Second Death’ (Stokes, 2015)

Erasing a memorialized account is a harm inflicted on the deceased. Platform discontinuation therefore poses an ongoing existential threat to mourning communities.



Online Afterlives (Sisto, 2020)

Digital culture has produced new immortality desires — from static memorial pages to AI-generated chatbots that simulate the deceased.

Platform Studies & Continuing Bonds



The Culture of Connectivity (van Dijck, 2013)

Platforms are not neutral conduits for connection. They embed commercial values — popularity, ranking, traffic — into the architecture of sociality itself.



Platformization & Deplatformization (van Dijck et al., 2021, 2022)

Platform ecosystems are volatile and uncured — they can be restructured, sold, or shut down overnight, with no guarantee for memorial content.



Continuing Bonds Theory (Klass, Silverman & Nickman, 1996)

Healthy grief involves sustaining — not severing — a connection with the deceased. Social platforms are uniquely suited to this ongoing bond.

The Research Gap & Study Aims



The Gap

Existing scholarship documents that digital remains are valued by the bereaved — but it does not document how communities act to preserve them against corporate threat. There is no systematic study of the emergent archiving practices users develop in response to platform precarity.



Study Aims

- Trace the emotional registers of digital mourning across 50 memorialized accounts.
- Map the topical structures of grief discourse using computational text analysis.
- Document the precarious material conditions under which digital memory survives.

Methodology: Corpus & Mixed-Methods Design

50

accounts
(27 Facebook, 23 Instagram)

2,847

individual posts

18,394

comments

≈412,000

words of text data

Corpus collected January 2020 – December 2024 · Inclusion: ‘Remembering’ status, English-language, 12+ months activity, 30+ posts



Two-Stage Sentiment Analysis

VADER (lexicon-based) + fine-tuned RoBERTa for grief-specific registers.
Inter-method agreement: Cohen’s $\kappa = 0.74$.



Structural Topic Modelling

Latent Dirichlet Allocation (Gensim); coherence-optimised at $k = 5$ topics ($C_v = 0.58$).



Qualitative Close Reading

180 purposively selected posts; constructivist grounded theory (Charmaz, 2014).



Research Ethics

AoIR (2020) guidelines; all accounts anonymised with alphanumeric codes.

Results: The Emotional Arc of Digital Grief

Figure 1: Sentiment Analysis of Memorialized Account Posts
(N = 50 Accounts, 2,847 Posts)

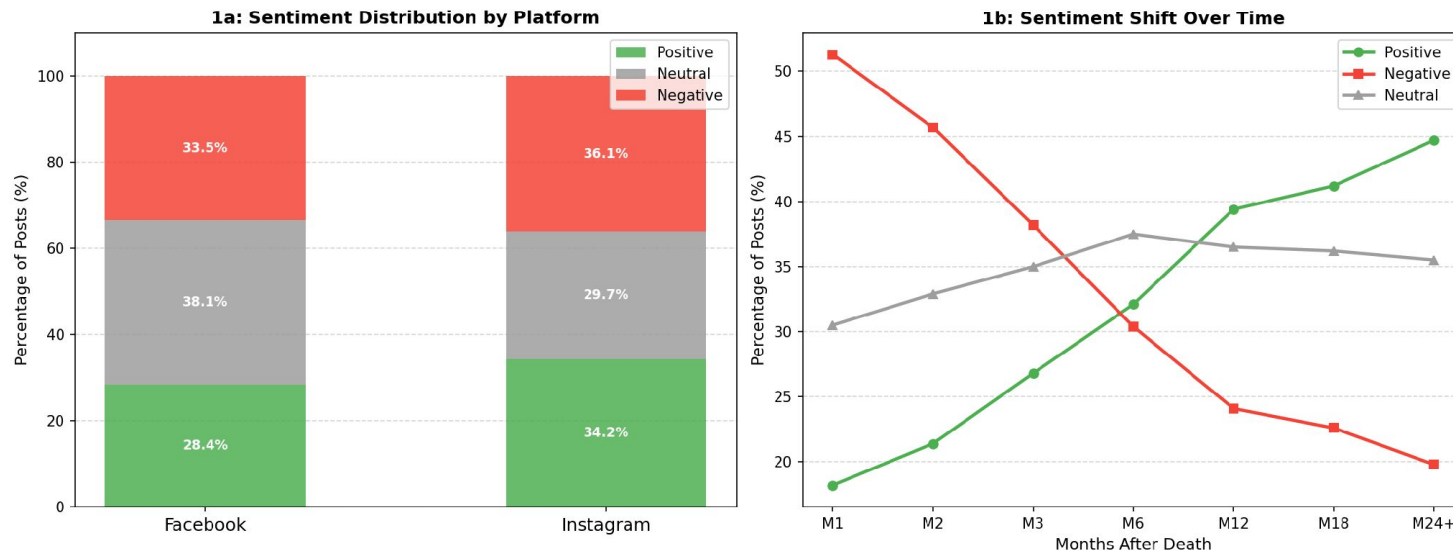
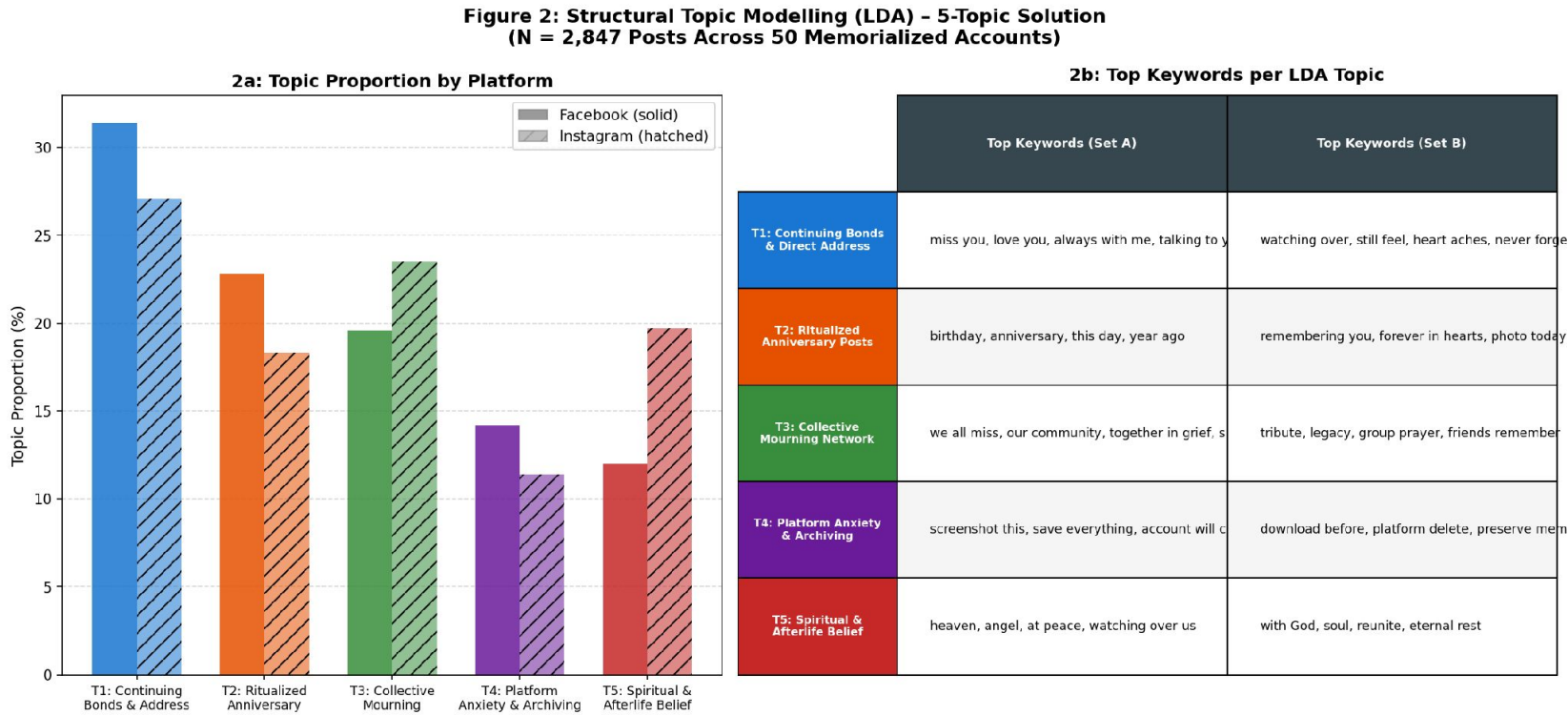


Figure 1. Sentiment distribution by platform and 24-month sentiment arc. Source: authors' computational analysis of 2,847 posts.

Key Takeaways

- Overall negative skew: 33.5% (FB) / 36.1% (IG) negative vs. 28.4% / 34.2% positive.
- Acute peak at Month 1 (51.3% negative) declines to a residual 19.8% by Month 24; positive sentiment rises from 18.2% to 44.7%.
- Mirrors Stroebe & Schut's (1999) oscillation model — but digitally elongated by persistent profile access.

Five Themes of Digital Grief Discourse



- 1 Continuing Bonds & Direct Address**
31.4% / 27.1% — dominant topic
- 2 Ritualized Anniversary Posting**
22.8% / 18.3%
- 3 Collective Mourning & Solidarity**
19.6% / 23.5% — stronger on IG
- 4 Platform Anxiety & Archiving**
14.2% / 11.4% — curatorial labour
- 5 Spiritual & Afterlife Belief**
12.0% / 19.7% — stronger on IG

Figure 2. LDA topic-modelling results (k = 5). Source: authors' analysis using Gensim (Python).

Platform Precarity & Community Archiving in Action

Figure 3: Platform Precarity Indicators & Community Archiving Behaviour

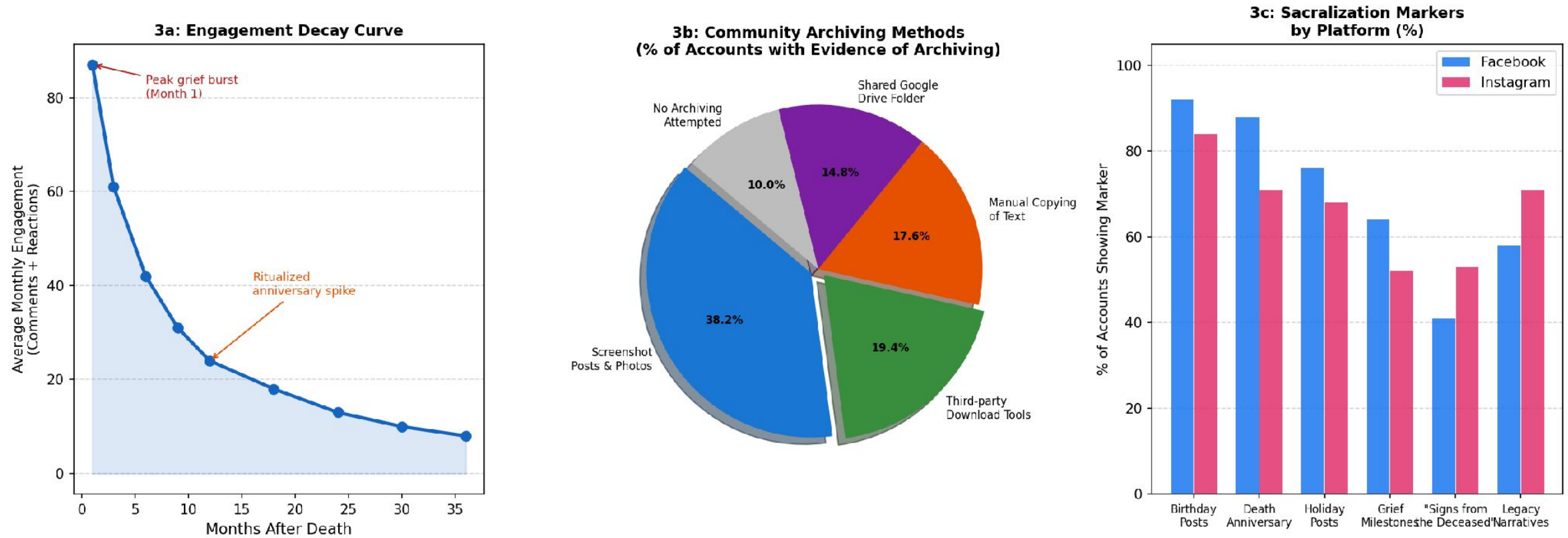


Figure 3. Engagement decay, community archiving methods, and sacralization markers. Source: authors' analysis.

Engagement falls from 87 to 8 interactions/month over 36 months, with a recurring 'anniversary spike' at Month 12. 38.2% of accounts show screenshot campaigns; 92% / 84% (FB/IG) show systematic birthday sacralization.

Key Finding: ‘Memorial Precarity Anxiety’

11.4% of Instagram accounts carried explicit ‘platform-anxiety discourse’ — fear that content will be lost, urgency about downloading, distress at deactivation notices.

These posts carried elevated anxiety scores despite otherwise-positive memorial sentiment — a grief-specific emotional state not previously named in the literature.



memorial precarity anxiety

a newly named emotional register at the intersection of grief and platform distrust

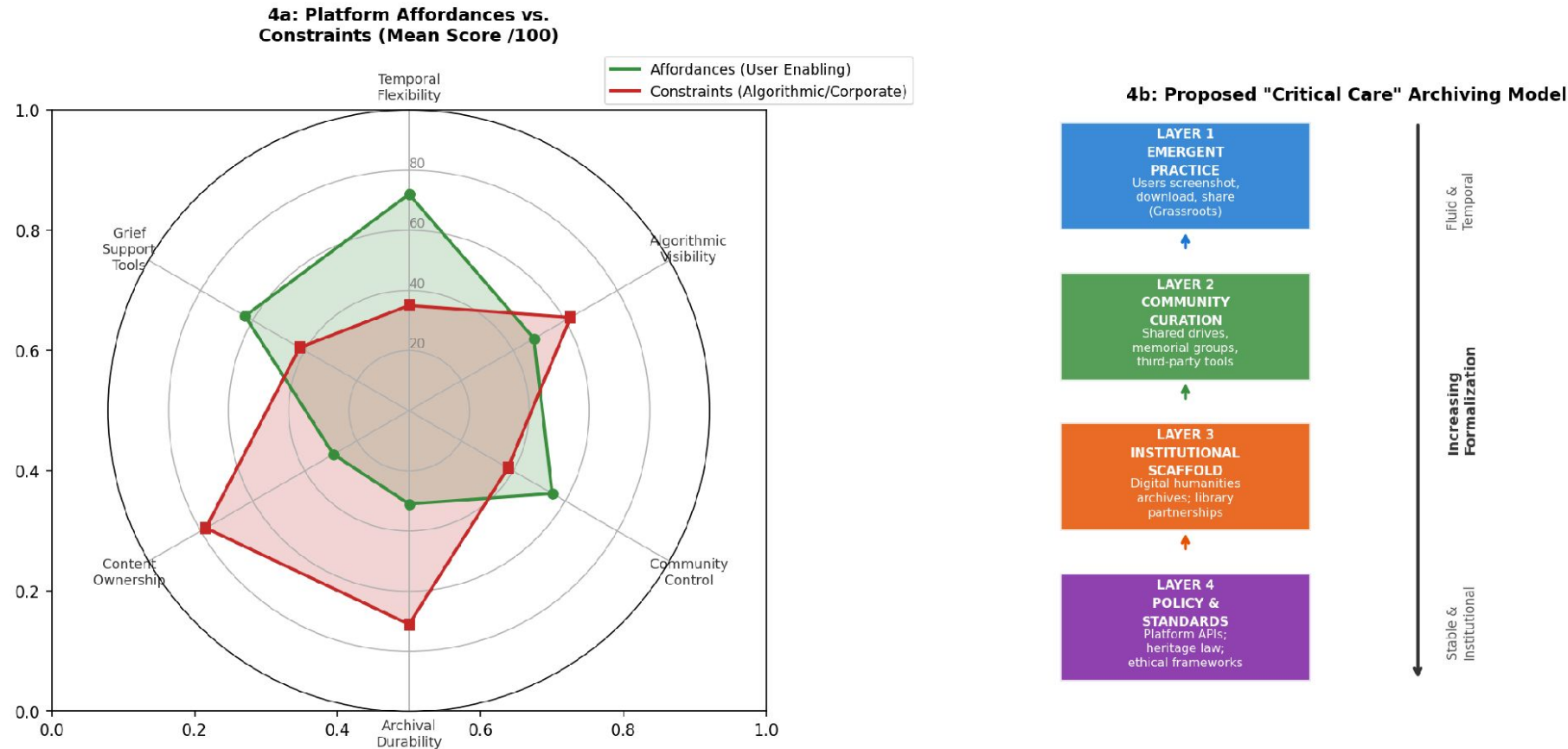
“

Please – before this page disappears – save every photo, every comment, every video. This is all we have left of him. Facebook doesn’t care about grief. Archive everything. Share this so people know.

— Post on account FB-14, 18 months post-death

From Diagnosis to Model: Critical Care for Digital Memory

Figure 4: Qualitative Coding Framework & Critical Care Model



Platforms score lowest on archival durability (mean 31/100) — no institutional guarantee of memorial persistence. In response, we propose a four-layer 'Critical Care' model, moving from grassroots practice to systemic policy reform.

Discussion: Implications for Three Audiences



Digital Humanists

Memorialized accounts are legitimate objects of cultural heritage study, requiring the same institutional care as physical archives.



Platform Designers

Current affordances are structurally inadequate to memorial needs — designing for grief requires a different logic than designing for engagement.



Policy Makers

Digital remains are cultural heritage; their dependency on commercial goodwill is a structural failure of digital governance.

The paradox: digital solidarity itself replicates the precarity it seeks to escape — third-party tools risk lockout, screenshots lose metadata, and shared drives carry their own commercial precarity. Institutional support (Layers 3–4) is therefore essential.

Conclusion: The Emergency Is Already Here

A mixed-methods analysis of 50 memorialized Facebook and Instagram accounts shows digital mourning to be richer — and more precarious — than existing scholarship has acknowledged.

An emotional arc

from acute loss to gradual restoration,
sustained over 24 months.

Five discourse genres

identified through structural topic modelling
of 2,847 posts.

‘Memorial precarity anxiety’

a newly named register, alongside
grassroots ‘digital solidarity’ archiving.

“The emergency of memory is already here. The response must be equally emergent.”

Thank you — Simanta Nandi

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